Bank, runs into a friend in the aisle of a supermarket and is accosted: ‘Why did you people raise the interest so much yesterday? My EMI has shot up by 800 rupees.’ I could relate to the embarrassment of my colleague who would have to say sheepishly that she works in a different part of the Reserve Bank, is not in the loop on interest rates and, in fact, knows as little as her friend! Embarrassment aside, this was also a foregone opportunity to demystify the Reserve Bank.

I believed that every staff member of the Reserve Bank should be broadly aware of the policy perspectives of the bank across its broad remit, irrespective of the narrow domain of his or her job chart in order to be an effective ambassador for the bank to the outside world. To operationalize this, we introduced a monthly thematic video conference, anchored in rotation by a specific central office department. The conference would link all the regional offices of the Reserve Bank, and the central office staff would run the agenda explaining the current policy perspectives. I also asked that the deputy governor and the executive director in charge of monetary policy do such a thematic video conference after each quarterly policy review so that all our officers could communicate the Reserve Bank’s policy rationale to the larger public with greater knowledge and confidence.

Recall what I said earlier about my effort to increase awareness about what the Reserve Bank does so that it can be held to account for its performance. I, therefore, attached a lot of value to a more decentralized dissemination of the monetary policy. My idea was that universities and think tanks across the country, especially in non-metro and second-tier cities, should hold special sessions to discuss and debate policy. I realized that this would not happen by mere exhortation, and at least in the early stages, the Reserve Bank had to act as the catalyst. I used to urge our staff, both in the central office in Mumbai and our regional offices across the country, to take the lead in this. Given the limited staff resources, our reach was modest; so we prepared a roster for balanced geographical coverage.

I got a call one late evening in May 2013 from a senior citizen in Nagaland profusely thanking me, in halting English, for sending someone